SPORTS

THE CYCLISTS MOVING MOUNTAINS

INDIA'S MOUNTAIN BIKERS ARE NOW GETTING THE PUSH THEY NEEDED TO SUCCEED ON THE WORLD STAGE





With mountain biking now a feature at the Asian Games and the Olympics, the CFI is doubling its efforts

In 2012, Shiven entered his first mountain biking race in Shimla. Though he finished third, he was disqualified for not wearing a helmet. It was a harsh lesson for Shiven, a teenager at the time, but it only strengthened his resolve. Wanting to explore his options as a professional cyclist, he moved to Manali four years ago. He also started working with a sports scientist in South Africa. His lone, single-minded battle has paid off. Shiven, 24, is today the reigning MTB (mountain biking) national champion and one of India's top cyclists. "It was an individual effort, but a lot has happened for the sport in the recent past," he says.

In July 2019, the Cycling Federation of India (CFI) sent the first Indian team to compete at the Asian Mountain Bike (MTB) Championships in Lebanon. A month-long camp was organised in Haldwani before the event—another first for mountain biking. It was a push in the right direction for athletes like Shiven, who had, until then, often put together their own resources to continue training and competing. With mountain biking now a feature at the Asian Games and the Olympics, the CFI can be seen doubling its efforts. For instance, the federation has now decided to send a team of seven riders to Turkey, where they'll train and race alongside some of the top mountain bikers in the world.

"It's the first time we are being sent on an exposure tour. The focus is not on results—it's about learning. It will help us as we target podium finishes at the Asian Games and Asian Championships," says Shiven. Back home, the CFI is trying to replicate the success they have had with track cycling, especially after they set up the National Cycling Academy in New Delhi in 2015. By April, they hope to get a mountain biking academy up and running at the Sports Authority of India (SAI) facility in Shilaroo, Himachal Pradesh. "We've identified the cyclists. A few had gone to the SAI centre in Patiala, but their visit was cut short due to Covid," says V.N. Singh, assistant secretary at CFI.

These developments have encouraged young riders like Kariksing Adonis Tangpu to pursue mountain biking full-time. Over the past year, he has worked remotely with a strength and conditioning coach, a nutritionist and an SAI psychologist. He shifted base from Mysuru to Imphal after receiving support from the Manipur Adventure and Mountain Biking Association (MAMBA). He has also found three private sponsors. "I could pursue the sport during my younger days thanks to my family's support, but things have really improved. There's a lot of learning ahead," says 19-year-old Tangpu. ■

–Shail Desai